



1861

DOWAGER EMPRESS CIXI TAKES CONTROL OF CHINA

When her young son succeeded Chinese Emperor Xianfeng as the Tongzhi Emperor, the Empress Dowager seized control in a bloodless coup. She adopted the name Cixi ("motherly and auspicious") and dedicated her life to the survival of the fragile Qing Empire. She ruthlessly manipulated events to control the succession of two more emperors before she died in 1908.

◀ Dowager Empress Cixi

1861 Victor Emmanuel II of Piedmont-Sardinia becomes king of Italy, beginning the country's reunification

1860



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FLORENCE NIGHTINGALE FOUNDS THE FIRST SCHOOL FOR NURSES

Famous for organizing the nursing of wounded soldiers during the Crimean War, Florence Nightingale transformed nursing into a profession and increased women's participation in the workforce by founding the Nightingale Training School in London.

◀ Florence Nightingale, relief

1862 Umar Tall conquers Massina in Mali and founds the Toucouleur Empire

1861-65 CIVIL WAR RAGES IN AMERICA



Angry at US President Abraham Lincoln's anti-slavery stance, several states withdrew from the Union, forming the Confederate States of America in 1860. Civil war broke out as the Union sought to reunite the US.

12-13 April 1861 The first shots of the war are fired when the South Carolina militia bombard the US garrison at Fort Sumter, near Charleston.

17 December 1862 At the Battle of Antietam, a Union army stalls the Confederate invasion of Maryland; it is the bloodiest single day of battle in American history.

1863 In the Emancipation Proclamation, Lincoln changes the legal status of enslaved people in the Confederacy; 3.5 million African Americans are made free.